

Chicago Tribune



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THURSDAY, MAY 29, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

4 Palestinians die in chaos at aid site

Israel claims Hamas boss killed in Gaza; Yemen also targeted

By Wafaa Shurafa, Samy Magdy and Melanie Lidman
Associated Press

DEIR AL-BALAH, Gaza Strip — Hundreds of Palestinians stormed a United Nations food warehouse Wednesday in Gaza in a desperate attempt to get something to eat, shouting and shoving each other and even ripping off pieces of the building to get inside. Four people died in the chaos, hospital officials

said.

The deaths came a day after a crowd was fired upon while overrunning a new aid-distribution site in the Gaza Strip set up by an Israeli and U.S.-backed foundation, killing at least one Palestinian and wounding 48 others, Gaza's Health Ministry said Wednesday.

The Red Cross Field Hospital said the wounded from that scene included women and children with gunshot wounds.

Meanwhile, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said his country killed senior Hamas leader Mohammed Sinwar, the brother of Yahya Sinwar, one of the masterminds of the militant group's Oct. 7, 2023, attack, who was killed by Israeli forces last year. Speaking before parliament, Netanyahu included Sinwar in a list of Iran-backed Hamas leaders killed by Israeli forces, apparently confirming his death in a recent airstrike

in Gaza.

In other developments Wednesday, Israel carried out airstrikes on the international airport in Yemen's capital, Sanaa, destroying the last plane belonging to the country's flagship airline.

The strikes came after Iran-backed Houthi rebels fired several missiles at Israel in recent days, without causing casualties. The Israeli military said it destroyed aircraft used by the rebels. It was not immediately clear if anyone was killed or wounded in the strikes.

In Gaza, the crowd of Palestinians on Tuesday broke through fences around the distribution site where thousands had gathered. An Associated Press journalist heard Israeli tank and gunfire and saw a military helicopter firing flares.

It was not clear whether Israeli forces, private contractors or others opened fire. The foundation said its military contractors had not fired on the crowd but "fell back" before resuming aid opera-

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JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Governor holds budget cards close to vest

Former Gov. Jim Edgar speaks Wednesday during the dedication of a reading room bearing his name at the Illinois State Library in Springfield. As the state legislative session winds down, Gov. JB Pritzker, seated behind Edgar, isn't offering any clues regarding his stance on the overall spending plan, but he's making clear his opposition to "broad-based" taxes to balance the state's budget. **Chicagoland, Page 2**

Bears, Pritzker hired outside consultants

Maneuvers suggest stadium talks deeper than publicly portrayed

By Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

As the Chicago Bears have waffled over the past year on where to build a new stadium, one constant has been Gov. JB Pritzker's skepticism about providing major public dollars to help fund the project.

But during that time, Pritzker

has spent \$100,000 in taxpayer funds for an outside legal consultant to advise the state in discussions with the team and the Bears have brought on an outside adviser with close ties to Pritzker's political operation and other Illinois Democrats, records show.

The maneuvers suggest talks between the two sides have gone deeper than has been portrayed publicly and shed new light on some of the behind-the-scenes positioning that has taken place during the yearslong push for

public dollars or changes in state law that could help facilitate the construction of a team-owned stadium.

The revelations came to light after the Bears' new adviser — a longtime political consultant who worked on local fundraising for last summer's Democratic National Convention in Chicago as well as on Pritzker's first campaign for governor in 2018 — reached out to the governor's chief of staff in a late April email sent just weeks before the Bears confirmed to the Tribune

that the team was shifting focus for stadium plans back to redeveloping the former Arlington International Racecourse.

"Hope you had a great weekend in NY," Leah Israel wrote to Pritzker's chief of staff, Anne Caprara, in an April 28 message sent to Caprara's personal email address and obtained by the Tribune through an open records request. "As you know, I've recently started working with the Chicago Bears and I'd appreciate

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Watchdog: CTA paid some to stay home

Certain employees didn't work at least 2 days a week, report says

By Talia Soglin
Chicago Tribune

For nearly five years, the Chicago Transit Authority paid a small group of employees to stay home and not work at least two days a week, a state watchdog has found.

The employees in question worked in the agency's vault operations unit, which is responsible for processing money taken from CTA fareboxes. Those workers were not able to perform any of their assigned duties from home, but were nevertheless assigned to work remotely at least two days a week since the beginning of the pandemic, continuing to do so even after the agency-wide return to office date in May 2022, according to a report from the Office of Executive Inspector General.

A total of 10 employees were paid just under \$1.13 million for days they were not working since the start of the pandemic, the OEIG found. The bulk of the payments were made between the onset of the pandemic and the agency's return-to-office date in May 2022, but the employees were paid \$303,932 for remote work between May 2022 and Feb. 1 of this year.

The report, dated Feb. 21, also determined that several CTA managers were aware of the practice of paying workers for remote days during which they could not work but "took no action to reduce or stop such waste."

"Although paying employees may have been necessary in the very beginning of the pandemic, the CTA's payment for no work continued week after week for five years," the report said. "No justifiable reason for this continued payment was provided in any CTA documents or by any of the

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INSIDE



CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Suzuki has risen to occasion this season

Seiya Suzuki — fresh off his Player of the Week honor — drives in an MLB-best 50th run in Cubs' walk-off win. **Chicago Sports**

Berlin, Kyiv plan to develop missiles

The long-range weapons systems would be free from any Western-imposed limitations on their use and targets. **Nation & World**

Hoover's federal sentence gets commuted by Trump

Founding Gangster Disciples kingpin will still serve state time

By Jason Meisner, Caroline Kubzansky and Sam Charles
Chicago Tribune

President Donald Trump has commuted the federal life sentence for infamous Chicago-born Gangster Disciples founder Larry Hoover, abruptly ending Hoover's yearslong quest to win early release under the First Step Act passed during Trump's first term.

The two-page order said Hoover's sentence was considered served "with no further fines, restitution, probation or

other conditions," and directed the U.S. Bureau of Prisons to release him "immediately," according to a copy of the document provided by Hoover's legal team.

The controversial move — part of a slew of clemency actions announced by the White House this week — appeared to have already sparked Hoover's transfer out of the supermax prison compound in Florence, Colorado, that he'd called home for the past two decades.

But Hoover isn't going free — he's still serving a 200-year sentence for his state court conviction for murder. Officials with the Illinois Department of Corrections have previously said

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Larry Hoover, founder of the Gangster Disciples, attends a parole hearing on Aug. 31, 1995, at Dixon Correctional Center. **JOHN DZIEKAN/TRIBUNE**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 71 Low 53

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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